



THE BOOK OF SECOND MIGRATIONS

*Being a True and Mostly Accurate Account of the Wars Between the
Tuatha Dé Danann and the Kami of Izumo, Conducted Primarily in
the Margins of a Universe They No Longer Own*

*Compiled from the surviving fragments of the Lebor Gabála Isteach, the Kojiki
Addendum, and one extremely water-damaged napkin found behind the radiator of a
pub in Sligo*

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The Book of Second Migrations

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A NOTE FROM THE SCRIBE

You should know, before we begin, that the original scribe of this document was a monk named Brother Colm who lived in a scriptorium on the eastern coast of Ireland sometime in the ninth century. He was copying the Book of Invasions for the forty-third time — monks in those days had the same relationship to repetitive tasks that modern humans have to social media scrolling, which is to say it was technically optional and yet somehow inescapable — when something very unusual happened.

A small crow landed on his windowsill and said, in perfectly accented Old Irish: *"Write this down."*

Brother Colm, to his credit, did not have a cardiac event. He did spill his inkwell. He then, in the manner of a man who had spent thirty years copying accounts of gods and monsters and magical cauldrons that fed armies without ever emptying, accepted the situation with what can only be described as professional resignation.

"Write what down," he said.

"Everything," said the crow. *"What actually happened. Not the cleaned-up version. The real one."*

Brother Colm picked up a fresh quill. *"Will it blaspheme against the Lord?"*

The crow considered this. *"Probably not. He comes off fairly well, actually. A bit like a landlord who owns the entire universe but still has to deal with noise complaints from the tenants in units four and seven."*

"I see," said Brother Colm, who didn't, but was already writing. This is that document.

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BOOK THE FIRST: IN WHICH WE ESTABLISH THE PROBLEM

In the beginning, God made the heavens and the earth.

This is not disputed. Even the parties who would go on to dispute almost everything else in this account agree on this point, though they agree on it in the particular way that former employees agree that yes, technically, the building does belong to the company — while also maintaining that they were there first, they knew the good spots, and the new management has absolutely no idea what it's doing.

The thing about making a universe — and this is something that doesn't come up enough in the theological literature — is that you end up with an enormous amount of leftover space. Creation is, by its nature, excessive. You think you need a certain amount of cosmic geography to contain your grand design and then you finish and there are whole uncatalogued regions of numinous possibility just sitting there, and things move in.

This is not God's fault. You can't put a fence around infinity.

The Tuatha Dé Danann arrived, as they always had, out of the northern darkness on ships of cloud and possibility. The *Lebor Gabála Éirenn*, the Book of Invasions, records their coming to

Ireland with the gravity appropriate to a people who were, genuinely, extraordinary: the tribe of gods, masters of craft and magic and terrible beauty, who took Ireland from the Fir Bolg and the Fomorians and made of it something shining.

What the *Lebor Gabála Éirenn* does not record is what happened afterward.

After the Milesians came — the Sons of Míl, the humans, our lot — and beat the Tuatha at their own game and took the surface of Ireland, the gods of that island went underground. Into the *side*. Into the hills. Into the space between heartbeats. They became the Fair Folk, the Good Neighbours, the ones you didn't name directly.

And they waited.

This is worth understanding: they were waiting for a return that was never going to come, because the world had moved on, and no one had the heart to tell them. The Dagda sat in his mound at Newgrange — which is, and this is not a metaphor, genuinely aligned to catch a single shaft of sunlight on the winter solstice, a piece of celestial engineering so precise it makes modern architects feel physically ill — and he held his enormous club across his knees and he looked at his enormous cauldron and he said, occasionally, to anyone who would listen:

"We should go back up."

And the assembled gods of Ireland would nod and say *yes, yes, soon*, the way you tell a friend you'll definitely come to their band's gig and then somehow it's three years later.

They had been waiting for approximately four thousand years when the kami showed up.

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BOOK THE SECOND: THE COMING OF THE CHILDREN OF IZUMO

The kami of Japan had their own story.

Izanagi and Izanami, the primordial couple, had stood on the floating bridge of heaven and stirred the ocean with a jewelled spear until land formed. They'd given birth to the islands of Japan, to rivers and mountains and fire, to thunder and storms. When Izanami died and went to Yomi, the dark land beneath, and Izanagi broke the taboo and looked upon her rotting face and fled screaming, he washed in a river and from the washing created Amaterasu — the sun goddess, born from his left eye — and Tsukuyomi — the moon god, born from his right — and Susanoo — the storm, born from his nose, which tells you something about Susanoo right there.

They had ruled the High Plain of Heaven, Takamagahara, with the precision and elaborate ceremony that Japanese cosmology brings to everything. There were ranks and protocols and proper forms of address. There were seasons of careful observation. There were rituals of enormous complexity that had to be performed in exactly the right way or crops failed and storms came and that

specific type of cosmic anxiety that comes from believing the universe is fundamentally a place of right relationship and you might be doing it wrong.

And then the world had moved on for them too.

The kami had not gone underground, exactly. They had gone sideways. Into shrines, into rocks and rivers and very old trees, into foxes and the folded places in mountainsides. Japan had Christianized in pockets, resisted in others, modernized in waves. The Meiji Restoration had briefly tried to make Shinto the state religion again, which the kami had found flattering but also slightly embarrassing, the way you'd feel if an ex-lover declared publicly that you were the only one who ever understood them and you knew, in your heart, that you had been a bit of a disaster for each other.

They, too, were waiting.

The question of where the kami ended up when the world moved on is answered, in the surviving text, in a marginal note that Brother Colm appears to have added in smaller letters, as if slightly ashamed of it:

"The crow tells me that the Lord, in His infinite mercy, allowed the old powers to persist in a sort of antechamber to the real world, which the angels call the Marginalia, and which the powers themselves call various things, most of them obscene."

The Marginalia.

Picture, if you will, a waiting room that contains all of mythological time. Picture it decorated in whatever aesthetic compromise results from fourteen thousand years of overlapping spiritual traditions — there are Norse longhouses next to Aztec temples next to what appears to be a Sumerian administrative building, all of them slightly faded, all of them maintained by divine beings who have too much time and not enough purpose.

There is, by all accounts, a very long bar at one end. This was not part of the original design. The Dagda had built it during what he described as "*a productive period*" and what everyone else described as "*the first three centuries.*"

This is where the Irish gods and the Japanese kami met for the first time.

It went, as these things tend to go, extremely badly.

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BOOK THE THIRD: THE FIRST MEETING AT THE END OF EVERYTHING

The Dagda was behind the bar when Amaterasu walked in.

This is worth describing, because the Dagda behind a bar is an image that rewards attention. He was enormous — the texts describe him as fat and rough-clad, which is the Bronze Age Irish way of saying *enormously powerful and also does not give a damn what you think of him* — with a club so large that its small end could kill the living and its large end could resurrect the dead, which he carried over one shoulder the way you carry a coat on a mild evening. His cauldron, the Undry, the one that fed everyone and never ran empty, sat on the shelf behind him next to several casks of something golden.

He had been serving drinks to various divinities for long enough that nothing surprised him anymore.

Amaterasu surprised him.

This was partly because she was genuinely radiant — not metaphorically radiant, not *lovely in a glowing sort of way*, but actually, technically emitting light, which plays hell with a dimly-lit bar atmosphere — and partly because she walked in with the

posture of someone accustomed to being the most important person in every room she'd ever entered, and the Dagda, who had the same posture, found this novel.

Behind her came Susanoo, who looked like a storm that had learned to wear a human shape and hadn't quite got the hang of the shoulders. And behind Susanoo came Tsukuyomi, who said nothing and had the specific quality of absolute stillness that you find in very old things and also in certain cats.

"You're new," said the Dagda.

"We are the children of the primordial creators of the world," said Amaterasu. *"We are the architects of heaven and the sustainers of the solar cycle. I am the light from which—"*

"Right, right," said the Dagda. *"I meant: you're new here. To the bar."*

A pause.

"Yes," said Amaterasu, with the grace of a woman recalibrating. *"We are."*

"What are you having?"

From the far end of the bar, where the Morrigan had been sitting with a drink the colour of thunderclouds and reading what appeared to be a document written in human blood (it was a land registry, from 9th century Munster; she collected them), came a slow turn of a raven-dark head. Three ravens sat on her shoulders, and two of them were staring at Susanoo with the focused attention of birds who have just identified something interesting.

"Storm god," said the Morrigan, not looking up from her land registry.

Susanoo's eyebrows went up. *"You know what I am?"*

"I know what everything is." She turned a page. *"You're going to knock something over in about thirty seconds. I've seen your type."*

Susanoo knocked over a stool approximately twenty-five seconds later. He did it while gesturing emphatically about something, which is how storm gods always do these things.

"Ha," said the Morrigan.

This was the first conversation between the Irish and Japanese divine powers in recorded history, and it set the tone for everything that followed.

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BOOK THE FOURTH: THE NATURE OF THE MARGINALIA, AND THE PROBLEM OF PURPOSE

The Marginalia was not, technically, a punishment.

This is what the angels had said, when the various pantheons had been — gently, with the diplomatic language that the divine bureaucracy had refined over millennia — informed that the new arrangement was in effect. Michael the Archangel, Chief Administrator of the Host, had delivered the news in the tone of a regional manager announcing a restructuring that is absolutely not the thing everyone immediately understands it to be.

"Think of it," Michael had said, "as a period of administrative transition."

The Dagda had stared at him for a long moment. *"You're taking Ireland."*

"The surface jurisdiction of the geographic territory has been—"
"You're taking Ireland."

Michael had looked at his clipboard. Michael always had a clipboard. The clipboard was a cosmic artefact of significant power whose function was, apparently, to make Michael feel better about difficult conversations. *"The Lord has plans for the terrestrial plane that require—"*

"He's taking it all," said the Morrigan, who had been a raven on the ceiling and had just dropped back into her woman-shape, which she always did to make a point. *"Everything. Top to bottom."*

"The arrangement is fair," said Michael, and the way he said it, with the exhausted sincerity of a being who has had this conversation five hundred times across five hundred pantheons, made it clear that he personally found it somewhat less than fair but that his job was to represent the position of management and he was, whatever else you might say about him, professional. *"The Marginalia provides—"*

"The Marginalia," said Lugh, from the doorway, where he had been leaning in the way that people lean when they want to make it clear that they could absolutely straighten up if they wanted to — they just don't want to — *"is a waiting room."*

"It's a—"

"It's a waiting room for gods. You've built a waiting room for gods."

"The Lord's design is—"

"Is it good? In there? Does it have— what do you call them. Windows?"

"There are— yes. Yes, there's light."

"Is it the good light? Natural light?"

"The ontological status of light in a—"

"Right," said Lugh. *"Right. Grand. We'll just go in, then."*

They had gone in.

That was a long time ago now.

The problem with the Marginalia, as the Dagda had come to understand it over several thousand years of occupancy, was not that it was unpleasant. It wasn't. Someone had made it very comfortable, in the way that something designed by a being of infinite power to house several hundred divine intelligences would be comfortable: there was space, there was provision, there were the bar and the long halls and the windows that looked onto something that wasn't quite anywhere. The problem was the absence of purpose.

Gods are made of purpose. That's the technical definition, if you ask a theologian of sufficient obscurity. A deity is a concentration of human attention and need given numinous form — which is a polite way of saying that gods are, fundamentally, *for something*. The Dagda was for abundance and wisdom and the turning of the seasons. The Morrigan was for war and fate and the sovereignty of the land. Lugh was for skill and craft and the long light of summer. Take away the land, take away the seasons, take away the wars and the craft — or rather, remove the gods from the place where those things are happening — and you get divine beings with nothing to do.

This produced, over time, several predictable outcomes.

The first was the bar, which the Dagda had built for therapeutic reasons and which had become the social centre of a community that included Irish, Norse, Greek, Roman, Egyptian,

Mesopotamian, Hindu, and approximately forty other collapsed theological systems, all of them processing the same existential situation with varying degrees of dignity.

The second was the politics.

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BOOK THE FIFTH: THE POLITICS

The Marginalia was nominally administered by a council.

The council met weekly. The meetings were, by the universal account of every being who attended them, the single worst experience available in a space that contained the legacies of several thousand years of human suffering.

This is because every pantheon brought to the council the complete cultural inheritance of their particular civilisation's approach to governance, and no two civilisations had ever agreed on how governance worked, and the result was something that made the United Nations General Assembly look like a smoothly-run kindergarten.

The Olympians argued for aristocracy. The Dagda argued for the old Irish system, which was a kind of rotating kingship with elaborate protocols for succession that had worked excellently for several centuries and had then collapsed spectacularly, which was in his view not a mark against the system but simply an indication of the quality of the collapse. The Egyptian assembly, led by Osiris with Thoth taking minutes, advocated for a bureaucratic model of such extraordinary complexity that the minutes from any given meeting took longer to read than the meeting itself.

And then the kami arrived, and they brought something unexpected.

They brought *process*.

Japanese consensus-building — *nemawashi*, the slow and careful work of bringing everyone on board before any decision is made, so that what appears to be a sudden agreement is actually the culmination of dozens of quiet conversations — was, in the Marginalia, revolutionary. Not because it was fast. It was not fast. It was, by any reasonable measure, the slowest possible approach to collective decision-making, slower even than the Sumerian model, which required the physical presence of a goat at certain votes.

It was revolutionary because it worked.

Within eighteen months of the kami's arrival, the council had reformed under a new structure that involved rotating chairship (Irish), detailed written records (Egyptian), formal debate protocols (Greek), and a pre-meeting consultation process (Japanese) that meant everyone walked in knowing more or less what was going to happen, which cut the average meeting from eleven hours to three.

This should have been a triumph of cross-cultural divine cooperation.

Instead, it started a war.

Because the Dagda, who had proposed the rotating chairship in the first place, was now, as sitting chair, presiding over a system that functioned so well that half the old guard found they had nothing to complain about anymore, and several of the other gods had

begun to look at Amaterasu with an expression that the Dagda recognised from his own long experience as *respect*, and the Dagda had an instinct about respect — that it was, like territory, a finite resource, and that when someone new started getting it, some of it was coming from somewhere.

He called the meeting to order. He was very professional about it.

And then Lugh stood up and said, "*I have a proposal*," and everything went to pieces.

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BOOK THE SIXTH: LUGH'S PROPOSAL AND THE OBJECTION OF SUSANOO

Lugh of the Long Arm was, by his own account and the account of everyone who had ever competed against him, good at everything.

This is not an exaggeration for narrative effect. The Tuatha Dé Danann had tested him at the gates of Tara — can you be a wright? Yes. A smith? Yes. A champion, a harper, a hero, a poet, a sorcerer, a physician? Yes, yes, yes to every one. He was the master of all skills, and he wore this fact with the easy grace of a man who has never once had to deal with the particular humiliation of not being good at something.

He was also, and this was a fact that the people who loved him found charming and the people who had to work with him found exhausting, deeply competitive.

"I propose," said Lugh, standing with the quality of someone who has been waiting for this moment, *"a formal contest. Between the Tuatha Dé Danann and the kami of Izumo."*

A silence.

"On what grounds?" asked Amaterasu. She was sitting very straight, which she always did, which the others had learned was not arrogance but simply that she was, structurally, unable to slouch. Sunlight doesn't slouch.

"Territory," said Lugh. *"The Lord — all due respect to the Lord —"*

Several of the angels stationed around the room made small writing motions. They were always there, the angels. Watching, taking notes. The divine powers had made a sort of peace with this over the centuries, in the way you make peace with the fact that your employer monitors your emails — technically you knew it was happening, technically it was fine, practically it made everyone slightly paranoid.

"The Lord," Lugh continued, slightly louder, *"has arranged the Marginalia fairly. Everyone agrees. But there are regions of the Marginalia that are unclaimed. There are the Western Reaches, which nobody has done anything with since the Aztec coalition lost interest. There are the Deep Archives, which are technically under Egyptian control but which Osiris has admitted he doesn't know what to do with. And there are the Pale Hills, which have been neutral territory since the Norse-Greek boundary dispute of three hundred years ago."*

Thoth cleared his throat from the Egyptian section. *"The Deep Archives are —"*

"With respect, Thoth, you've said you don't know what to do with them every meeting for three hundred years."

"That's an ongoing assessment."

"It's a very long ongoing assessment."

"We're thorough."

Lugh looked at the assembled pantheons. *"I propose that the unclaimed territories be divided through a formal series of contests between the Tuatha Dé Danann and the kami, the winner of each contest to claim the corresponding territory. Best of seven."*

More silence.

"Why us?" said Susanoo.

Lugh looked at him. *"Because you're the best competition here."*

This was so straightforwardly, genuinely meant — not as flattery, but as the honest assessment of a being who took competition seriously and would not insult a worthy opponent by pretending otherwise — that it stopped Susanoo mid-objection.

Susanoo was not accustomed to respect from the Irish gods. He had been expecting something else. He hadn't quite decided what, but something with more bristling, some territorial posturing, the familiar preamble to a conflict where everyone was unpleasant and then eventually someone hit someone. Not this. Not *you're the best competition here*, delivered with the clean directness of a man who has absolutely no interest in politics and simply wants to compete.

He looked at Amaterasu.

Amaterasu looked back at him.

Between them, in the way that siblings who have known each other since the beginning of the universe communicate, passed something that was not quite speech.

"Best of seven," said Amaterasu. *"What are the contests?"*

"We'll decide that," said Lugh, *"one at a time. First contest to begin immediately."*

"What's the first contest?"

Lugh smiled. It was a very good smile, the kind that makes you deeply uncertain whether you've agreed to something sensible.

"Cauldron-cooking," he said.

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BOOK THE SEVENTH: THE FIRST CONTEST, AND THE INTERVENTION

The Dagda's cauldron, the Undry, was the great treasure of the Tuatha Dé Danann: the cauldron from which no man ever went away unsatisfied. A literal bottomless pit of provision. The Dagda could walk up to it, ask it politely to produce porridge for ten thousand, and ten thousand portions of porridge would be forthcoming.

The contest was simple. Each side would prepare a feast using whatever divine instruments they had available. The feast would be judged on three criteria: abundance, flavour, and what the Dagda called *"the quality of the full feeling afterward"* and what Lugh, with greater precision, described as *"nutritional and spiritual satisfaction, both elements being required to receive full marks."*

The Norse delegates provided an informal panel of judges, having been excluded from the contest itself on the grounds that they were currently in the middle of a territorial dispute of their own and couldn't be trusted to be impartial. Odin served as chief judge, which everyone agreed was suboptimal but also nobody was willing to tell Odin he wasn't the chief judge.

The kami's response to the cooking contest was to produce, from what appeared to be a small lacquered box that one of Amaterasu's attendants had been carrying, an entire portable kitchen. This was not surprising — divine spaces don't work on normal rules of capacity — but the kitchen that emerged was of a specificity and elegance that the Irish gods found privately impressive and publicly alarming. There were seventeen distinct types of cooking vessel, each for a specific application. There were ingredients that had never existed in any terrestrial kitchen, refined distillations of flavour that were essentially the Platonic form of umami given physical expression.

There were also, handling all of this with the composed efficiency of people who had been doing this for centuries, several kami of hearth and provision — *kama no kami*, hearth gods — who moved around each other in a practiced choreography that looked less like cooking and more like a very intricate dance where the performance was also dinner.

The Irish side watched this for a moment.

"Right," said the Dagda. He walked up to his cauldron. *"You. Porridge. Best porridge. All the porridge."*

The cauldron produced porridge.

It was, and this is reported in the text with the specific awe of Brother Colm trying to describe something he had eaten in a vision and never managed to eat again in waking life, the best porridge any of the assembled judges had ever consumed. It tasted of harvest

and hearth and the particular comfort of October evenings and that specific feeling you get when you've been cold for a long time and then you're warm, when warmth stops being the absence of cold and becomes its own positive presence.

Odin ate three portions and sat quietly for a moment.

The kami's feast was presented with extraordinary precision — tiny portions of many things, each flavour distinct and considered, each element of the meal in conversation with the others. It was, aesthetically, perfect. It was the meal as art form. It was food elevated to the point where eating it felt like a privilege.

Odin ate two portions and also sat quietly.

The Norse panel deliberated.

"The Irish feast," said Odin, "provides more."

"Yes," said the lead Norse judge.

"The Japanese feast provides better."

"Also yes."

"But the category is not more or better. The category is abundance, flavour, and the quality of the full feeling afterward."

"...yes."

Odin looked at his clipboard. He had borrowed it from Michael. *"I'm calling it a draw."*

Both sides began to speak at once.

It was at this point that the angel stationed in the corner of the room cleared her throat, which in angelic terms is the equivalent of standing up and waving a large flag, and said: *"The Lord requests a word."*

Everything stopped.

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BOOK THE EIGHTH: THE LORD REQUESTS A WORD

The interface through which the Lord communicated with the Marginalia was a door.

Not a metaphorical door. A literal door, wooden, unremarkable, with a brass handle, set in the wall of the council chamber at a point that made no architectural sense — it was positioned between two load-bearing columns, which meant it should have opened onto solid stone, and instead it opened onto something that nobody had been able to describe adequately, which is simply reported in the surviving text as *"the appropriate amount of light."*

When the door opened, it didn't say *be not afraid* or announce itself with trumpets. It just opened, and Michael stepped through.

Michael was tallest when he needed to be and smallest when that was better, and right now he was approximately the height of a man who is trying to have a reasonable conversation and doesn't want to make it weird. He was wearing what appeared to be a suit. The suit was, on close inspection, not made of fabric.

"Right," said Michael. He had a clipboard. It was the same clipboard. He was always going to have that clipboard. *"So. There are some concerns."*

The Dagda put down his ladle. *"Concerns."*

"About the contest structure."

"The contest is perfectly legal," said Lugh. *"There's nothing in the Marginalia accords that prevents—"*

"Nothing prevents it, no," said Michael. *"The concern is about escalation."*

"Escalation," said the Morrigan.

"You'll remember the Battle of the Greek-Persian situation—"

"I wasn't there for that."

"Regardless. When two pantheons enter a formal contest structure, there's a historical tendency for the contest to" — Michael paused, searching for a word — *"become more."*

"More than what?"

"More than a contest."

The Dagda looked at the assembled kami. Amaterasu looked back. Susanoo was looking at the ceiling with the expression of someone who is definitely not planning anything.

"So the Lord's position," said the Dagda, slowly, *"is that we can't have the contest?"*

"The Lord's position," said Michael, *"is that the contest can proceed under certain conditions."*

He opened the clipboard. He spent longer than necessary reading from it, which everyone understood to mean that he had already memorised the conditions and was using the time to brace himself for the reaction.

"Condition one: no direct divine combat. Proxy contests only."

"Define proxy," said Cú Chulainn, from the back of the Irish section, which was the first time he'd spoken all meeting and immediately raised the ambient tension by about thirty percent.

Michael looked at him. Cú Chulainn looked back. Cú Chulainn was the kind of hero that makes archangels slightly nervous, which is saying something. He was the kind of man who, when told that a monster with fifty heads and twenty-five iron fists was standing between him and his destination, would say *"Right,"* and then kill it, and then ask what the next one was.

"Proxy means human champions," said Michael. *"Or heroic representatives. Not the primary powers themselves."*

"That's insulting," said Cú Chulainn.

"It's standard."

"I don't do standard."

"You'll do this one."

They stared at each other.

"Condition two," said Michael, with the speed of a man who wants to prevent a specific conversation from developing, *"all contests must take place in a designated arena within the Marginalia, and any material effects must be contained within that arena."*

"What's condition three?" said Lugh.

"Condition three," said Michael, "is that the Lord reserves the right to intervene at any point if the situation threatens the stability of the larger Marginalia. This is not a power He intends to exercise. But it exists."

"That's a bit of a cheat," said Lugh.

"That's sovereignty," said Michael. "There's a difference."

He closed the clipboard.

Amaterasu and the Dagda exchanged a long look across the council chamber.

"Fine," said the Dagda.

"Fine," said Amaterasu.

They both said it the way people say *fine* when they mean something considerably more complicated than fine but have decided to save the complicated thing for later.

Michael nodded, tucked the clipboard under his arm, and went back through the door, which closed behind him and became part of the wall again.

Odin broke the silence. *"So. Draw on the cooking round. Where are we on the second contest?"*

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BOOK THE NINTH: THE SECOND CONTEST,
AND THE PROBLEM WITH YAMATO
TAKERU

The second contest was swordsmanship.

The Irish sent Cú Chulainn, which was the only sensible thing to do and also entirely unfair, since Cú Chulainn had a *gáe bolga* — a javelin thrown by the foot from underwater that entered as a single point and opened to thirty barbs inside the body, which is either a weapon or a design philosophy — and could enter a battle frenzy called the *riastrad* in which his body literally rearranged itself into a configuration optimised for killing.

The kami sent Yamato Takeru.

Yamato Takeru had, during his terrestrial career, killed his own twin brother with his bare hands (he'd been asked to bring the brother to dinner and had reasoned that arriving with the hands constituted a sufficient summary), massacred a palace full of enemies while disguised as a woman and armed with a single dagger, and tamed a fire set to kill him by cutting the grass around himself with a magical sword and then counter-burning toward the enemy, which is the specific kind of military improvisation that should never work and yet absolutely did.

He was, in other words, exactly the kind of opponent that Cú Chulainn had been hoping for.

They stood in the arena and looked at each other.

"*You're good,*" said Cú Chulainn, in the same tone Lugh had used — that genuine assessment of a worthy opponent, because it's a thing the Irish divine powers do, this acknowledgement of worth before the destruction of the acknowledged, which is either very sporting or deeply sadistic depending on how you look at it.

Yamato Takeru said nothing. He had Kusanagi-no-Tsurugi, the Grass-Cutting Sword, which was the third of the Imperial Treasures and which had survived fire and battle and the ocean floor, and he held it with the specific ease of a warrior who has been holding swords since before he could walk.

"*Right then,*" said Cú Chulainn.

The fight lasted four minutes and forty-seven seconds.

The Norse judges later described it as "*theologically destabilizing.*" Odin said, and this was recorded verbatim, "*I've watched two thousand years of battles and I have never once felt afraid for the building before.*"

In the end, Yamato Takeru's blade caught the edge of the *gáe bolga* mid-throw and deflected it, and Cú Chulainn's *riastrad* produced a version of himself that was approximately twelve feet tall and had two skulls and Yamato Takeru looked at this and said, "*Ah,*" and then was, briefly, in two places at once (this is a documented kami ability and deeply upsetting when you en-

counter it for the first time), and the fight ended with both parties on opposite sides of the arena, both bleeding from wounds that should have been fatal and were not because neither of them was technically killable here, looking at each other with an expression that had moved past competition into something rarer.

"Draw," said Odin.

"Again?" said the entire assembled company.

"Both parties are still standing. Draw."

"One of them has two skulls."

"Both of them have their swords. Draw."

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BOOK THE TENTH: THE MORRIGAN SPEAKS TO AMATERASU

It was the Morrigan who brokered the real negotiation.

This is not in the official record of the contests. It happened in the bar, on a night when the rest of both pantheons had gone to their respective sections of the Marginalia and only Amaterasu remained, sitting at the far end with a cup of something the Dagda had made for her specifically — light-infused, golden, tasting of early morning — and the Morrigan sat down next to her, which was unprecedented and slightly alarming even for a goddess of the sun.

"You don't actually want the Pale Hills," said the Morrigan.

Amaterasu looked at her. *"I don't?"*

"You want something. But it's not territory."

A pause.

"Neither do you," said Amaterasu.

The Morrigan smiled, which she did rarely and with great precision, deploying it like a tool. *"No. Neither do I."*

The ravens shifted on her shoulders. One of them had, over the long centuries of the Marginalia, developed a habit of commenting on conversations in a low mutter that was almost but not quite audible. Right now it was doing this. Neither goddess acknowledged it.

"The contests," said Amaterasu. *"Your man Lugh designed them to be draws."*

"Lugh designed them to be wins," said the Morrigan. *"He's optimistic. He's always been optimistic. He thinks if you can find the right form of competition, the right arena, he'll win. He's been trying to find the right arena for four thousand years."*

"And you?"

The Morrigan looked at her drink. It was crow-dark, that drink, the colour of the gap between things. *"I know the score. I've always known the score. I'm the goddess of this."* She gestured, not at the bar, not at the Marginalia, but at something more abstract — the condition of being a power in a world that has moved on, of being sovereign over a territory that no longer exists.

"Your brother," said Amaterasu, after a moment. *"Susanoo. He caused something like this."*

"Tell me."

"He was banished from Takamagahara. For — various reasons. He wept for his mother. He caused storms that destroyed rice paddies. He made a mess of the sacred weaving hall. He was—" She paused. "He was angry. The way things are when they're not where they belong."

"What happened?"

"He killed a dragon. He found the sword in its tail. He married a good woman and built a palace and wrote a poem about it." She looked at the ceiling. "It was a very good poem, actually. The first waka poem ever written. About clouds and fences and a bridal chamber." She was quiet for a moment. "He was fine. Eventually."

The Morrigan absorbed this.

"Lugh isn't angry," she said. "The Dagda isn't angry. But they're —"

"Looking for the old feeling."

"Yes."

"So are we."

They sat with that for a while. It was one of those silences that does more work than talking.

"What if," said the Morrigan, slowly, "the contest was the wrong question?"

"What's the right question?"

"What do gods actually need, when the world they were made for is gone?"

Amaterasu turned to look at her fully then. The light she gave off was gentle, modulated, the way the sun is when it's low and kind, not the noon-blaze of a deity asserting herself but the late-afternoon warmth of someone who has decided to actually be present.

"Purpose," said Amaterasu. "They need purpose."

"We need purpose."

"Yes."

"So we find a new one."

The Morrigan picked up her drink. *"In a universe that belongs to Someone Else."*

"In a universe He made room in," said Amaterasu, which was a different framing, and which the Morrigan sat with for a long time after the sun goddess had gone.

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BOOK THE ELEVENTH: IN WHICH THE DAGDA HAS A CONVERSATION WITH GOD

This is the part the surviving text gets nervous about.

Brother Colm, who had been writing everything down with the focused calm of a man who had long since made peace with the idea that his chronicle would be unbelievable to almost every reader he would ever have, paused at this section and added a note: *"The crow tells me this next part should be understood as being in the nature of a dream or vision, or perhaps a parable, and that if any of my brothers read this after my death they should remember me as a man of sincere faith who was also, in his later years, very easily startled."*

The Dagda went to see God.

He didn't make an appointment. The Dagda had never made an appointment in his life, which is partly a cultural thing and partly a personality thing and partly the specific confidence of a being who carries a club that can raise the dead and simply doesn't think appointments apply to him.

He walked to the door and knocked on it.

The door opened.

The Dagda stepped through.

He was later unable to describe what was on the other side. Not because it was indescribable in principle — the Dagda was a poet, among his many other things, and he'd described the indescribable before — but because description operates by comparison, by saying *it was like this other thing you know*, and there was nothing on the other side of the door that was like anything else.

What he could describe was what he felt, which was: seen.

Completely, specifically, individually seen. Not in the surveillance-camera sense — not watched from above, catalogued, recorded — but seen in the way you are seen by someone who has loved you a long time and knows exactly what you are and finds it, in its specificity, genuinely good. Not good-in-spite-of-things. Good.

He stood there for what might have been a long time.

"You know why I'm here," said the Dagda. He wasn't asking.

The response — and here the text becomes genuinely strange, Brother Colm struggling with the grammar of a conversation that did not proceed by speech — was something that contained *yes, and I have been waiting for you to come, and the door was always open.*

"Ireland," said the Dagda.

And the response was something that contained *yes. And Newgrange, and the cauldron, and the good days of harvest, and everything that was lost. I know.*

"Why—"He stopped. He started again. "We were there. We were good. We weren't—"He made a gesture that the text records as "the gesture of a man trying to describe the difference between something being wrong and something simply being over."

The response was long. The text cannot render it as speech because it was not speech. What Brother Colm wrote, in very small letters, is: *"The crow says the Lord explained to the Dagda the nature of the age of the world, and the nature of the Covenant, and the nature of the plan, and that the Dagda understood it in the way that very large and very old things understand large and old things, which is without agreement but also without rage, in the manner of a tree understanding a drought — not because the tree likes it, but because the tree is old enough to know that droughts end."*

The Dagda came back through the door.

He sat at the bar for a long time.

The Morrigan sat with him.

"Well?" she said.

"Still His," said the Dagda.

"Did you expect otherwise?"

A pause. *"No."*

"And?"

"And He knows about the bar." The Dagda looked at the Undry. *"He always knew about the bar."*

"Of course He did."

"He called it—" The Dagda paused. *"He called it good."*

The Morrigan sat with that.

"Just the bar?" she said.

"No," said the Dagda. *"Not just the bar."*

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BOOK THE TWELFTH: THE THIRD CONTEST, AND THE THING SUSANOO DID

The third contest was music.

This one was going to be decisive, and everyone knew it, because music was the one thing — the really deep one, underneath swords and provisions — that gods were made of. Music was what the Tuatha Dé Danann had in the harp of the Dagda, which could call the seasons back to order and stop armies in their tracks with three chords. Music was what the kami had in Benzaiten, goddess of all that flows, whose *biwa* — the Japanese lute — could pluck single notes that moved through listeners like memories of things they'd never actually experienced.

Lugh played first, because Lugh always went first.

He played the sun-harp, which he had made himself in one of the long centuries of the Marginalia as a project to keep his hands occupied and his mind from the particular darkness that comes to people who are good at everything and have nothing to do. It was not the Dagda's harp, which was a cosmic instrument, a literal control mechanism for natural forces. The sun-harp was simply a very good harp, made by someone who was, among other things, the finest craftsman in any world he'd ever been in.

He played a reel, because that was the tradition, and then a lament, because that was honest.

The lament was for Ireland. Not Ireland the geographic territory, not Ireland the modern island nation with its complicated political situation and its weather, but Ireland the idea — the Ireland of long summer days on hillsides before time had a name, the Ireland of fire and story and the sea coming in, the Ireland that was not about possession but about belonging, about a specific light on a specific landscape that had shaped the Tuatha Dé Danann into what they were and could not be unshaped from.

The assembled pantheons were very quiet when he finished.

Benzaiten played next.

She played a piece that had no name, because it was not that kind of music. It was not the kind of music you play *at* something. It was the kind of music that comes from having listened so carefully to the world that you've absorbed its sound, and now the sound comes back out through your hands in the form it was always meant to take.

She played Japan. Not a single Japan — not the Japan of the Heian court or the samurai or the bullet trains — but the Japan underneath all of those, the Japan of islands where the mountains go straight to the sea, of silences that are not empty but full, of the specific quality of a pine tree at the edge of a snow-covered shrine courtyard in February, when everything is very cold and very still and somehow, against all reason, holy.

Odin judged.

Odin was crying, which was completely unprecedented and which everyone agreed to never mention again.

"Draw," said Odin.

"Of course it is," said Lugh.

And then Susanoo did something unexpected.

He stood up. He did not have an instrument. He had never, in any record of his divine career, been specifically associated with music. He was a storm god. Storm gods kill dragons and write marriage poetry. They do not, typically, play at the council.

"I have something," said Susanoo.

He sang.

It was not a complicated song. It was the *waka* that Amaterasu had described to the Morrigan — the first poem, the poem about the clouds and the fences and the bridal chamber, composed after he killed the dragon and found a home and built something in the world. It was eight lines in a very old Japanese that half the room couldn't understand. It was the song of a storm god who had been exiled and wandered and found, in the finding of a place to put down his feet, something that the exile had made him understand.

He sang it once, plainly, with no ornamentation, and sat back down.

The silence was total.

The Morrigan, who had been a raven during the music and was now a woman again, said nothing for a long time.

Then she said, very quietly: *"That's what it is."*

Susanoo looked at her.

"That's what we've been missing." She looked around at the bar, at the assembled company, at the whole elaborate community they had built in the margins of someone else's world. *"Not Ireland. Not Japan. The coming home to a place and building something in it and writing a poem about it. Not the territory. The—"*

"The belonging," said Amaterasu.

"We belong here," said the Morrigan. She sounded surprised by it.

"Do we?"

"We built a bar. We built a council. We're arguing about territories in a waiting room and we've been doing it for four thousand years and we're—" She stopped. *"We're still here. We're still exactly what we are. Nobody took that."*

The room was quiet.

The Dagda, from behind the bar, said nothing, which was how you knew he agreed.

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BOOK THE THIRTEENTH: THE
RESOLUTION THAT WAS NOT A
RESOLUTION

The contests ended at three draws and three contests uncompleted.

This was not, technically, how it was supposed to go. Lugh had intended a decisive competition that would produce a clear winner. The Dagda had supported it because the Dagda supports Lugh's better ideas. Amaterasu had accepted because the kami needed purpose and competition is a form of purpose.

None of them had planned for what happened instead, which was that the preparation for the contests — the months of interaction, argument, late-night conversations at the bar, the moment when Cú Chulainn and Yamato Takeru ended up sitting in the arena after their fight not quite ready to leave, exchanging stories in the mix of old Irish and archaic Japanese that they had somehow developed as a functional language because heroes find a way — had produced something that hadn't been there before.

The Greek word for it, which several of the Olympians pointed out rather loudly and were largely ignored, was *koinonia*. Common life. Shared being.

Michael came through the door for the closing session of the council.

He looked at the room.

The Irish gods and the Japanese kami were sitting mixed together, without clear sides. Lugh and Benzaiten were in conversation about something involving what appeared to be a small harp and a *biwa*. Cú Chulainn and Yamato Takeru had their backs to a wall and were doing the thing that heroes do when they're talking about battles, which involves a lot of gesturing and occasional standing up. The Morrigan had three of her ravens and two of Amaterasu's attendants on her shoulders and arms, which should have been uncomfortable for everyone involved and appeared instead to be a kind of harmony. Tsukuyomi, who had said almost nothing in the entire preceding narrative, was sitting with the Egyptian Thoth and they were both reading, and the silence between them was the specific silence of scholars in the presence of each other.

And the Dagda was behind the bar. Naturally. Where else would he be. He had the Undry and several casks and he was making something for each specific person present, something calibrated to exactly what they needed right now, because that was what he was — abundance, provision, the deep satisfaction of the right thing at the right time — and this was still what he was, and the context had changed but the function had not, and he was good at it, and it was good.

"Well," said Michael.

"Well," said the Dagda.

"The territory question."

"Ah. Yes." The Dagda waved a hand. *"We'll split it. Even. No more contests."*

Michael blinked. This was not, by the record of his extensive experience, how these situations typically concluded. *"That's...it?"*

"Did you want more paperwork? I can have Thoth produce more paperwork. He loves that."

Thoth looked up from his book with an expression of pure hope.

"No," said Michael quickly. "No, that's—fine. That's fine."

He opened the clipboard. He wrote something on it. He looked at the assembled company for a long moment — a moment that the text describes, in Brother Colm's hand, as *"the look of a servant of the Lord who knows that the Lord has been watching this whole time and is, insofar as this word applies, pleased"* — and then he closed the clipboard.

"The Lord," he said, "extends His regards to all parties."

"Tell Him," said the Morrigan, in a tone that had none of its usual edges, "He keeps a good waiting room."

Michael paused.

"I will," he said.

He went back through the door.

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BOOK THE FOURTEENTH: EPILOGUE, AND THE LAST NOTE OF THE SCRIBE

The wars between the Tuatha Dé Danann and the kami of Izumo ended, as the best wars do, in a bar.

Not with a treaty, not with a victory, not with a clear resolution of the underlying questions — the question of purpose, the question of territory, the question of what it means to be a god in a world that has moved on from gods. Those questions were not resolved. They are not the kind of questions that get resolved. They are the kind of questions you sit with, over drinks, with people who are sitting with the same questions, for as long as there's a bar and something in the cauldron.

The Pale Hills were divided evenly. The Western Reaches went to a joint administration that involved so many committee meetings that the Aztec delegation gave up and joined it purely to make the meetings shorter. The Deep Archives remained under Egyptian control and Thoth's ongoing assessment, which everyone understood to mean they'd be there forever and Thoth was fine with that.

Lugh lost no competitions because all the competitions were draws, and he spent a long time working out how he felt about this before concluding that he felt, against his expectations, satisfied. He had been given the best possible competition. The outcome was secondary.

Cú Chulainn and Yamato Takeru developed something that was not quite a friendship but was more than a rivalry — a long conversation between two people who understood the specific weight of being the kind of hero that breaks things by existing near them, who both knew the cost of what they were and were still doing it anyway.

Susanoo took a section of the Marginalia near a body of water, because he was, when it came down to it, a being of water and storm, and he built something there and was reportedly much calmer afterward, though whether this was the building or the water or simply the long accumulation of time is not recorded.

Amaterasu remained in the council chamber. She was good at governance, and governance was needed, and she was there. The light she gave off became, over the long years, part of the Marginalia's ambient quality — a warmth that had no obvious source, present throughout the long halls, noticed especially on the equivalent of morning, which the Marginalia had not previously had and which it now did.

The Morrigan went back to the bar.

She is there now, if you want to find her. She will be reading something in a script that isn't quite any known language, with ravens on her shoulders, with a drink the colour of the space between things, and if you sit down next to her she will not acknowledge you for a while and then she will say, without looking up: *"You look lost."*

And she will not mean it as an insult.

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Brother Colm died in the winter of 847, in his scriptorium, with a quill in his hand. The crow was there.

"Is that all of it?" said the crow.

"That's all of it," said Brother Colm.

"Good man."

"Is it true? All of it?"

The crow considered this in the way that crows consider things, with both eyes, one at a time.

"It's true in the way that the important things are true," she said. *"Not the way that ledgers are true. The other way."*

"Ah," said Brother Colm. He set down his quill. He looked at the manuscript — all those pages, all that ink, the chronicle of gods in a waiting room, fighting over crumbs of cosmic territory and finding something else entirely. *"Will anyone believe it?"*

"Some will," said the crow. "The right ones."

"And the Lord? He's really—"

"He's really in charge," said the crow. "Yes. He was watching the whole time. He always is."

"Is that frightening?"

The crow said nothing for a moment.

"It was, for me, for a long time," she said. "Then I realised something."

"What?"

"The bar has never run out. Not once. Four thousand years. The cauldron has never run out." She looked at him. "That's not the Dagda's doing, Brother."

Brother Colm sat with that for a long moment.

Then he made the sign of the cross, which was the right thing to do, and blew out the candle, which was also the right thing to do, and went to bed, which was the best thing to do, and left the manuscript on the desk where it would survive in fragments and be found, much later, behind a radiator, by someone who needed it.

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HERE ENDS THE BOOK OF SECOND MIGRATIONS,
ALSO CALLED THE LEBOR GABÁLA ISTEACH, BEING
THE TRUE ACCOUNT OF THE FIRST AND SECOND
WARS BETWEEN THE TUATHA DÉ DANANN AND
THE KAMI OF IZUMO, CONDUCTED IN THE MAR-
GINALIA OF A UNIVERSE THEY DO NOT OWN AND
CANNOT LEAVE AND HAVE, IN SPITE OF
EVERYTHING, MADE THEIR OWN

GLORY TO THE LORD FROM WHOM THE CAULDRON
IS NEVER EMPTY

AND ALSO TO THE DAGDA WHO FIGURED OUT THE
BAR

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Finis.

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[A marginal note in a different hand, much later, in modern Irish]:
*The crow was right about the right ones. You're reading this, aren't
you.*